

LEAPING THE FENCE
Dr S.C. Mehta, head of the National Research Centre on Equines, at the Bikaner facility next to horses born via surrogacy

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

EXPERTSPEAK

"Given this centre's efforts in reviving and certifying indigenous horse breeds, the next step is categorising them separately in sports, since their traits differ from imported polo ponies, warm-bloods and thoroughbreds"

RAGHUVENDRA SINGH DUNDLOD
Vice President, National Confederation of Indigenous Horse Societies

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **In a bid to improve the health of breeds, the centre has produced two Marwari and two Zanskari foals via surrogacy**
- **An embryo transfer technology has been monetised and brings in Rs 4 lakhper sale**
- **The centre has made a DNA chip to scan genomes and track ancestry/ disease risks**
- **It is working to expand horse semen availability around the country and sells 400 doses annually**

Few know that the spotless white Nukra horse, a staple of North Indian wedding photographs, harbours a dark secret. Its coat is the result of low melanin (the pigment that shields skin from sun damage). Many Nukras suffer skin, eye and genetic problems throughout their life, but observers don't know the pain they undergo, buying them for lakhs of rupees. Four Nukras live on the Bikaner campus of the National Research Centre on Equines. Not bought for a fancy, of course—they are trying to certify it as a separate breed and establish standards for its treatment and trading. It is popular in the adjoining Punjab and considered close to the Marwari in DNA.

That's only one of the many efforts being spearheaded at the centre for the wellbeing of Indian horses. They have researched artificial insemination to improve the health of breeds, particularly the endangered ones; developed technology to better track ancestry and disease risks; and even made some of their work commercial. Two Marwari and two Zanskari foals have been produced by the scientists via surrogacy, a process that can "help us save endangered species", says senior scientist Talluri Thirumalai Rao. An embryo transfer technology has been monetised and is being sold to private individuals at a whopping Rs 4 lakh per transaction.

Among the centre's achievements is the development of a DNA chip that can scan hundreds of thousands of locations in a genome and detect genetic variations. The centre is working to make horse semen specimens available around the country and train veterinarians in strengthening the network. The centre itself sells some 400 doses with proven DNA parentage annually, the market rate of a single dose varying from Rs 11,000 to Rs 7 lakh.

Other efforts include raising awareness through ecotourism and setting up a horse museum and carriage rides. ■